

DISSERTATION FORMAT GUIDE

Word Count: 15,000 – 20,000 words

1 Typography & Page Setup

Before you type a single word of your dissertation, you must set up your Word document correctly. Your examiner will check these settings — incorrect formatting leads to mark deductions even if your research is excellent. Follow every rule below without exception.

Setting	Required Value	Notes
Font face	Times New Roman	Use this font throughout
Font size	12 point	Size 12 only
Font style	Normal (not bold, not italic)	Normal style — bold/italic only where specified
Alignment	Left-justified	Left align all body text
Line spacing	1½ line spacing	Main Body only
Paragraph gap	12 pt space between paragraphs	12 pt gap between paragraphs
Paper size	A4	A4 paper only
Margins	2.5 cm on all four sides	All four sides — 2.5 cm
Printing	Single-sided only	Single-sided print
Headings	Initial Capital Letters — NOT ALL CAPITALS	First letters capitalised — ALL CAPS forbidden

Header & Footer Rules

Position	Content	Example
Top Centre	Short title of your dissertation	Machine Learning in Healthcare
Top Right	Page number	1, 2, 3 ...
Bottom Left	Your full name	Jane Smith
Bottom Right	Award name	MSc Computing

Heading Style — Do vs. Don't

✓ Correct — Initial Capitals	✗ Wrong — All Capitals
Literature Review	LITERATURE REVIEW
Research Methodology	RESEARCH METHODOLOGY
Analysis of Findings	ANALYSIS OF FINDINGS
Critical Evaluation	CRITICAL EVALUATION

2 Word Count Requirement

15,000 – 20,000 words

Your dissertation must be between 15,000 and 20,000 words. This word count covers the Main Body only — from Chapter 1 (Introduction) through Chapter 9 (Conclusion). It does not include the Preamble (title page, abstract, table of contents) or the End Matter (references, bibliography, appendices). Going significantly under or over this range will affect your grade.

Section	Included in count?
Title page, Abstract, Contents	NO — not counted
Chapter 1 — Introduction	YES
Chapter 2 — Literature Review	YES
Chapter 3 — Methodology	YES
Chapters 4–7 (core chapters)	YES
Chapter 8 — Critical Evaluation	YES
Chapter 9 — Conclusion	YES
References, Bibliography, Appendices	NO — not counted

- Always check your word count using Tools > Word Count in Microsoft Word before submission.

3 Three Main Parts of the Dissertation

Every MSc dissertation at Wrexham University must be divided into exactly three parts. Each part has its own spacing rules, page numbering scheme, and required contents. Think of it as a sandwich — the Preamble opens it, the Main Body carries all your work, and the End Matter closes it.

Part 1 — Preamble	Part 2 — Main Body	Part 3 — End Matter
• Title page • Acknowledgements • Abstract • Table of Contents • List of Figures • Glossary (if needed)	• Chapter 1 — Introduction • Chapter 2 — Literature Review • Chapter 3 — Methodology • Chapters 4–7 (track-specific) • Chapter 8 — Critical Evaluation • Chapter 9 — Conclusion	• References • Bibliography • Appendix 1 — Project Proposal • Appendix 2, 3... etc. (numbered A1.1, A1.2, A2.1...)
Single spaced Title page: NO number Rest: Roman nos. ii, iii, iv...	1½ line spacing Pages restart at 1 Each chapter = new page Sections: no new page	Single spaced Page nos. continue from Main Body

Page Numbering — Detailed Rules

Section	Number Style	Notes
Title page	None	Title page is NEVER numbered
Acknowledgements → Glossary	ii, iii, iv, v...	Starts at ii (i is the invisible title page)
Chapter 1 → Chapter 9	1, 2, 3, 4...	Page numbering restarts fresh at 1
References → Appendices	Continues from body	No restart — numbers flow on from Main Body

4 Title Page Layout5 Chapter Structure — Both Tracks

Your dissertation follows one of two tracks depending on your project type. A research-based project involves surveys, experiments, or data analysis. A product-based project involves designing and building a software system or application. Both tracks share Chapters 1, 2, 3, 8, and 9. Only Chapters 4–7 differ.

Ch.	Research-based	Product-based
1	Introduction	Introduction
2	Literature Review	Literature Review
3	Methodology	Methodology
4	Findings	Investigation and Analysis
5	Analysis of Findings	Design
6	Evaluation of Results	Implementation
7	Discussion	Evaluation of Product
8	Critical Evaluation of Project	Critical Evaluation of Project
9	Conclusion	Conclusion

- Chapters 4–7 (highlighted above) are the only ones that differ between the two tracks.

6 Chapters 1, 2 & 3 — Foundation Chapters

Chapter 1 — Introduction

- Research background and context — why does this topic matter?
- Problem statement — what specific problem are you solving?
- Research aims (one main aim) and objectives (several specific targets)
- Scope and limitations — what is included and excluded?
- Dissertation overview — briefly describe what each chapter covers
- **Do NOT include deep technical detail — that comes in later chapters**

Chapter 2 — Literature Review

- Group related papers by themes — do NOT list papers one by one
- Compare and contrast what different researchers found
- Identify where researchers agree and where they disagree
- Highlight the gaps that existing research has NOT answered
- Explain how YOUR research will fill those gaps
- Critical discussion is required — not simple summaries

Chapter 3 — Methodology

- State your research approach: qualitative, quantitative, or mixed method
- Explain your data collection method: survey, experiment, interview, dataset
- Justify your tool and technology choices — why those tools?
- Include ethical considerations if human participants are involved
- Explain validity and reliability — can results be trusted and repeated?
- Provide enough detail that another researcher could replicate your study

7 Chapters 4–7 — Where the Two Tracks Diverge

Research-based Project (Surveys · Experiments · Data)

Research Track — Chapters 4–7

4 Findings

- Present your raw data, results, measurements — exactly as collected
- Use tables, charts, and graphs to display results clearly
- Do NOT interpret or explain what results mean yet — save that for Ch. 5
- Be objective and factual throughout

5 Analysis of Findings

- Now interpret and explain what your Chapter 4 results actually mean
- Identify patterns, trends, anomalies, and significant observations
- Link the analysis back to your research objectives from Chapter 1
- Support every claim with evidence from your data

6 Evaluation of Results

- Critically judge how well your results answered your research objectives
- Were the results better or worse than expected? Why?
- What does this tell you about the research question?

7 Discussion

- Compare YOUR findings with the literature you reviewed in Chapter 2
- Where do your results agree with previous researchers? Where differ?
- Explain any unexpected findings or contradictions
- This chapter connects your original work back to existing knowledge

Product-based Project (Software · System · Application)

Product Track — Chapters 4–7

4 Investigation and Analysis

- Deep-dive into the problem your system will solve
- Gather and document both functional and non-functional requirements
- Analyse existing similar systems and their strengths and weaknesses
- Justify the need for your proposed system

5 Design

- System architecture and design — overall structure of your solution
- UML diagrams: use case, class, sequence, activity diagrams

- Database schema and entity-relationship (ER) diagrams
- UI wireframes and screen flow designs

6 Implementation

- Describe how you actually built the system — tools, languages, frameworks
- Include key code snippets with explanations (not entire codebase)
- Show screenshots of the working system
- Explain any challenges encountered and how you resolved them

7 Evaluation of Product

- Present your testing approach: unit testing, integration, user testing
- Show and discuss test results — what passed? What failed? Why?
- Compare the final product against your original requirements (Ch. 4)
- Include any user feedback received

8 Chapters 8 & 9 — Same for Both Tracks

Chapter 8 — Critical Evaluation of the Project

This is one of the highest-weighted chapters — examiners look for honest critical reflection. Simply saying 'everything went well' will earn you very few marks here.

Area	Symbol	Key questions to answer
Strengths	✓	What did you achieve? What worked as planned? Did you meet your aims?
Weaknesses	✗	What did not go as planned? What were the shortcomings of your approach?
Constraints	■	Time, data availability, tools, equipment — how did they affect your work?
Future Work	→	If you had more time/resources, what would you extend, improve, or investigate?

Chapter 9 — Conclusion

- Restate your original aims and objectives from Chapter 1
- Clearly state whether you achieved each objective — and to what extent
- Summarise your key findings or the key outcomes of your product
- Give one or two brief practical recommendations
- Close with a strong statement about your work's contribution to the field
- **Keep it concise — typically 2 to 3 pages only. NO new ideas or references here!**

■ Chapter 9 must NEVER introduce new arguments, new literature, or new data. It is purely a summary.

9 End Matter — References, Bibliography & Appendices

After Chapter 9, your dissertation continues with the End Matter section. This is all single spaced, and page numbers simply continue from wherever the Main Body ended.

Item	What it contains	Numbering
References	Every source you cited in-text — these MUST appear here	Continues from Main Body
Bibliography	Sources you read and consulted but did not directly cite	Continues from References
Appendix 1	Your original Project Proposal document — always Appendix 1	A1.1, A1.2...
Appendix 2+	Survey forms, raw data, extra diagrams, code listings, ethics forms	A2.1, A2.2...

10 Pre-Submission Checklist

Before you submit your dissertation, work through every item on this checklist. Green items are things you **MUST** do. Red items are things you must **NEVER** do.

Things You **MUST** Do

- ✓ Font is Times New Roman, 12pt, Normal style, left-aligned
- ✓ Line spacing is 1½ in Main Body; single spacing in Preamble and End Matter
- ✓ Paper is A4 with 2.5 cm margins on all four sides
- ✓ Dissertation is printed single-sided only
- ✓ Title page has no page number whatsoever
- ✓ Preamble pages use Roman numerals: ii, iii, iv, v...
- ✓ Main Body page numbers restart from 1
- ✓ Every chapter begins on a completely new page
- ✓ Sections (1.1, 1.2...) do NOT start new pages — they continue
- ✓ Headings use Initial Capital Letters — e.g. 'Literature Review'
- ✓ Header contains short title (centred) and page number (top-right)
- ✓ Footer contains your name (left) and MSc Computing (right)
- ✓ Appendix 1 is your original Project Proposal
- ✓ Word count is between 15,000 and 20,000 words (Main Body only)

Things You **Must NEVER** Do

- ✗ DO NOT use ALL CAPITAL LETTERS in any heading — ever
- ✗ DO NOT put a page number on the title page
- ✗ DO NOT introduce new ideas, data, or references in Chapter 9
- ✗ DO NOT hide weaknesses in Chapter 8 — honest reflection is required
- ✗ DO NOT print double-sided
- ✗ DO NOT go under 15,000 or over 20,000 words in the Main Body

■ If in doubt about any formatting rule, visit your supervisor during office hours before submission.

Good luck with your dissertation!